

A Day in Hanoi

You need to be up early to catch some of the best sights, but no day in Hanoi is complete without a breakfast of *pho*, so buy some on the run.

MORNING Take an early morning trip to **Hoan Kiem Lake** ("Lake of the Returned Sword"), in the heart of the **Old Quarter**, to admire the lake and watch locals exercising before work. Then take a taxi to **Ho Chi Minh's Mausoleum**, which is only open until 11:00 AM. The marble building is a place of pilgrimage for many Vietnamese, and its grounds contain the **Presidential Palace** and **Ho Chi Minh Museum**.

AFTERNOON Hop on a local bus (an experience in itself) or take a taxi to the **Vietnam Museum of Ethnology**. Vietnam is home to countless hill tribe minorities and this modern museum gives a fascinating insight into their history and way of life.

EVENING After a day of culture, some relaxation is overdue, so return to the **Old Quarter** and make your way to **Bia Hoi Corner** (Luong Ngoc Quyen/Ta Hien). Sink into one of the tiny plastic chairs on the sidewalk and drink the cheapest draft beer in town.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Hanoi's **Noi An International Airport** lies 28 miles (45 km) outside the city. There are **taxis**, **minibuses**, and **public buses** to the downtown.

WHERE TO STAY

Make sure you have the address of your hotel, as unscrupulous operators can give their hotels the same names as successful ones.

The Hanoi Fortune Hotel (inexpensive) is close to Hoan Kiem Lake. www.hanoifortunehotel.com
Hotel Elegance Ruby (moderate) is a cool, classy retreat from the busy Old Quarter outside. www.hanoielegancehotel.com

The Sofitel Metropole (expensive) has long been the choice of diplomats and celebrities. www.sofitel.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.vietnamtourism.com



Right The many tastes and textures of *pho* come from its great mix of long-braised, freshly steamed, and raw ingredients

Below The busy district of Dong Xuan Market at the western end of the Old Quarter

